

The Seedling Shelf

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Forgotten Aisle

The Labyrinth Library had a smell for every section, and Alana had catalogued them all. Biography smelled of cedar and old ambition. Natural History smelled like pressed ferns and careful guessing. Poetry smelled, inexplicably, of lemons.

Aisle Seventeen smelled of rain that had not happened yet.

They found it on a Wednesday in the low afternoon, when the light inside the labyrinth had gone the particular golden color of something about to become something else. SPARK had been following a trail of magnetic anomalies along the east wall — small tremors, he said, like a signal repeating itself just below audible frequency — and the anomalies had led them away from the main reading rooms, past the map wing, past the corridor of atlases arranged by ocean, and into a section of shelving that looked as if the library had grown it by accident and then quietly forgotten to mention it.

The shelves here were not like the others. They were lower — just above Natalia's head — and made from pale wood the color of birchbark, with knotholes that had been carved into small archways. The books on them were arranged differently too. Not by subject or author. Not alphabetically. They were arranged, as far as any of the sisters could tell, by how long they would take to read. The shortest ones sat at one end, no thicker than a folded napkin. The longest ones stretched the full height of the shelf and had laddered spines like accordion files.

Between the shelves, in the long planters built into the base of each unit, something was growing.

Not flowers. Not exactly plants. Small, paper-colored shapes — almost translucent, pale as new parchment — pushed up through dark soil in clusters of three or four, each one curled shut like a leaf about to unfurl. They had the texture of onion skin if onion skin could hold the ghost of a watermark. You could hold one up to the light and almost see words in it.

"Seedlings," Natalia said quietly, crouching to look without touching. "Made of paper."

"Not made of paper," SPARK corrected, his sensor tilted at a precise thirty-degree angle of intense interest.

"Composed of something adjacent to paper. Cellulose fibres with a refractive index closer to vellum. And each one has a unique signature pattern."

Maya had her nose six centimeters above a cluster of seedlings and was sniffing thoughtfully. "They smell like the inside of a very good book on a day when you really needed one."

"What do we do with them?" Alana asked. She had her notebook open already.

The shelf did not answer. But three seedlings tilted in their direction, the way sunflowers track a moving window of light, and waited.

Chapter 2 — The Art of Planting a Bookmark

There was a sign, as it turned out. There is almost always a sign in the Labyrinth Library — not because the

library lacks faith in its visitors, but because it has excellent taste in typography and enjoys any opportunity to use it.

This one was carved into a beam above the first shelf, in the rounded lettering the library reserved for important instructions that did not want to seem intimidating: Plant what you cannot yet finish. Return when you are ready to begin again.

Beside the beam, hanging from a hook with the casual confidence of something that had been waiting there for years, was a basket of bookmarks. These were not ordinary bookmarks. They were made of a thick, cream-coloured material that was warm to the touch, faintly textured, and — Natalia noticed this immediately — faintly luminous at the edges when the light hit them from the side. Each one was blank.

"They're for planting," Alana said, turning one over in her hands and studying it with the careful attention she gave anything that had mechanical implications she had not yet identified.

"How do you plant a bookmark?" Maya asked.

SPARK projected a faint diagram onto the shelf planter. "Historical cultivation data detected in the shelf framework. Cross-referencing. Bookmarks are inscribed with the reader's intention — what they want to read, what they wish they could finish — and pressed into the soil at the base of the planter. Growth takes between one and seven days."

"What grows?" Natalia asked.

"A seedling," SPARK said. "Corresponding to the intention."

They each took a bookmark from the basket. Maya sat on the floor immediately and wrote with the library pencil she kept behind her ear, tongue between her teeth, letters large and decisive: The story about the dragon who decided to be a librarian instead, if that story exists somewhere. Alana wrote more carefully: A book about engineering that begins honestly, with all the things that didn't work before the things that did. Natalia sat with her blank bookmark for a long time before writing: The book I haven't been brave enough to start.

They pressed the bookmarks into the soil at intervals, pushing them in with their thumbs until only the top edges showed above the dark earth.

SPARK pressed nothing. He observed. But near the end, when he thought none of them were watching, Natalia saw him lean down and hover his sensor very close to the soil where her bookmark had gone in. She said nothing about it.

Three days, the shelf framework had said.

They came back in two.

Chapter 3 — Reading Aloud to Sleeping Things

The seedlings from their own bookmarks were there by the second morning — pale, curled, paper-thin, each one leaning in a different direction as though trying to orient itself toward something. Maya's was the tallest, already four centimeters, with edges that were beginning to separate from their furled shape. Alana's was stockier and held very still, as if thinking. Natalia's had not unfurled at all but was a deep, translucent gold that was prettier for being less opened.

But none of them bloomed.

The library — because the library always communicated its rules through inference rather than announcement — provided the answer on a small card that appeared overnight, propped against the planter's edge in the manner of a menu card at a formal dinner. The handwriting was narrow and pleased with itself:

Seedlings require voice to bloom. Read aloud within one arm's reach. One reader at a time. Patience is not optional.

"Read aloud?" Maya said. She looked at her seedling with great affection and zero surprise. "We just have to read to them."

"Read what?" Alana asked.

"Anything, I think," Natalia said. She had already settled cross-legged in front of the planter and was opening the small book of short myths she kept in her coat pocket for emergencies.

She read the first one — six paragraphs about a river that wanted to be a road — in a steady voice, neither loud nor soft, with the even rhythm she used when she was reading something she was actually inside rather than just passing through. By the third paragraph, her seedling had uncurled a millimeter. By the sixth, it had opened enough to catch the light and refract it into a thin band of amber across the soil.

It did not fully bloom. But it breathed differently — an intake, an expansion, a held stillness that was not the same as being closed.

"It's listening," Natalia said.

Maya immediately began reading to hers from a natural history book she had found in the adjacent section about the migratory patterns of birds who navigated by smell. Her voice was too fast at first. She slowed when she noticed the seedling curling tighter instead of opening. She slowed further. She tried to mean each sentence while she said it, not after.

Alana read from her engineering notebook — not equations, but the observation journal she kept alongside them — about the bridge she had tried to build from lolly sticks and the three different ways it had failed before the fourth way held. The seedling opened exactly as far as she got in the telling, and stopped when she stopped.

"They're following us," Alana said, and something in her voice that usually stayed behind her competence came through. "They're actually following."

SPARK said nothing. He simply kept recording, and the sensor that served as his eye was pointed at Natalia's gold seedling, which had opened, very slightly, when no one but him was looking.

Chapter 4 — Tending the Neglected Garden

Aisle Seventeen looked, on closer inspection, like a place that had been attended to once — carefully, lovingly, with intent — and had then been left to manage without company for too long. The planters at the far ends of the shelving ran had seedlings crowded in them in uneven clusters, some overlapping, some leaning on their neighbors for structural support in a way that was touching but not ideal. A few had reached their maximum unfurled state and held there, open but not quite bloomed, like doors that needed a final push they had not received.

"These have been here a long time," Natalia said, running a finger along the edge of a planter near the back wall where the light barely reached. The seedlings here were the palest of all, almost entirely translucent, and they leaned toward the main aisle as if they had been hoping, for some time, that someone would come in that direction.

"At least a year," SPARK said. "Dust accumulation on the planter rims indicates sustained absence. And these seedlings are at an advanced growth stage — they should have bloomed months ago."

"They just needed someone to read to them," Maya said, and there was something in her voice that was not quite anger and not quite sadness but lived in the neighborhood of both.

They made a plan, the way they always made plans: Alana mapped the aisle on graph paper in ten minutes, numbering each seedling cluster one through twenty-two. Natalia cross-referenced the inscribed bookmarks whose tops still showed above the soil, reading the intentions each original planter had written. Maya took the map and began moving through the aisle like a person with purpose and a schedule, settling beside each cluster and reading.

She read anything that felt right. A story about a lighthouse keeper who learned semaphore from seagulls. Three chapters of an adventure about twins on a raft. A poem about the color blue in seventeen varieties. The seedlings did not care about relevance. They cared about presence — about a voice that was genuinely in the room with them, not somewhere else while the mouth was moving.

By late afternoon, seven of the twenty-two clusters had bloomed: small, complete, paper-pale flowers that opened all at once and then held themselves very still, as if not wanting to startle anyone. They did not smell of anything in particular. They sounded, faintly, like the moment just before a page turns.

Alana marked each bloomed cluster on her map with a gold star. Then she looked at the remaining fifteen and said, very practically, "We're going to need more days."

"Yes," Natalia said, already sitting beside the nearest unread cluster with a book open in her lap. "We are."

Chapter 5 — The Voice That Wouldn't Work

On the third day, Alana could not read aloud.

This was not a mystery with a complicated solution. The solution was that reading aloud in front of things that were listening — truly listening, not politely listening while thinking about lunch — made Alana's voice do a thing she did not like, which was the thing where it went smaller than she intended and then smaller again, until what came out was a sort of technical ghost of the sentence she had meant to deliver with full confidence.

She tried three times, sitting in front of a cluster of seedlings that had turned toward her the moment she sat down, anticipating. Her first sentence came out normally. Her second came out correctly but with insufficient conviction. Her third sentence went sideways in the middle and arrived with a question mark she had not intended. The seedlings settled back into a neutral lean.

Maya, who had been watching from the next planter over, said nothing, which was more helpful than anything she could have said.

Natalia came and sat beside Alana on the flagstones. She did not make a suggestion. She opened her book and began reading aloud, her voice the reading voice she had developed over years of reading to anyone who would listen — even (especially) SPARK, when his battery ran low and he needed the ambient warmth of language to keep his processing stable. The seedlings in Alana's cluster turned toward Natalia's voice.

"That's cheating," Alana said quietly.

"It's borrowing," Natalia replied, not stopping. "There's no rule about one voice at a time."

Alana watched the seedlings unfurl in response to her sister's reading. Then she picked up her engineering notebook and read from it — not a story, but a sequence of careful observations she had made about the planter construction, how the pale birchwood joints were fitted without adhesive, relying on geometry and grain. She did not read it to the seedlings. She read it aloud to herself, because that was something she did sometimes when she was thinking, and it did not require conviction so much as genuine attention.

Three of the seedlings in the cluster began to unfurl.

SPARK, who had been hovering at a respectful distance, made a small sound of interest. "Theory," he said. "Reading does not require performance. It requires presence. The seedlings respond to genuine engagement, not projection."

Alana looked at her notebook, then at the seedlings, then at her notebook again.

She turned to the next page and kept reading — about the weight ratios of the planter shelves, about the angle of the knotholes relative to the main corridor light, about all the small, precisely observed things that she found genuinely interesting — and by the end of the page, the cluster had bloomed entirely.

"Hm," Alana said, which was what she said when something important happened and she needed a moment to catalogue it correctly.

"Good hm or complicated hm?" Maya asked from the other side of the aisle.

"Both," Alana said. "As usual."

Chapter 6 — The Seedling That Would Not Open

There was one seedling that would not bloom.

They found it on the fifth day, tucked at the end of the longest planter run, half-hidden behind a knot in the wood that stuck out like a small, indifferent elbow. It was the same pale parchment color as all the others but denser — more opaque, as if whatever was inside it was packed more tightly than the rest. It had been read to, several times, in the course of their work through the aisle. It had responded — they had seen it lean and unfurl a little — but each time, before it reached the point of full bloom, it drew back in.

Not dramatically. Not suddenly. Just a slow, deliberate retreat, the way someone takes a step toward something and then changes their mind and makes it look like they were stretching.

"There's something in it that's harder," Natalia said. She was crouching in front of it, reading the top of its planting bookmark, which she could just make out above the soil. The handwriting was very small, cramped, as if the intention had been written quickly before the writer could change their mind: A story I started and couldn't finish, because I didn't know if I was allowed.

She sat back and looked at her sisters.

"I didn't know if I was allowed," she repeated. "Allowed by what?"

"Allowed by themselves, probably," Maya said. She had stopped pretending to read to the next cluster and was looking at the reluctant seedling with the expression she wore when she was being serious, which was different from her regular expression in the placement of her eyebrows. "That's what that usually means."

SPARK hovered closer to the seedling. "The signature pattern of this seedling is different from the others we have catalogued. It has a secondary layer. A kind of... echo pattern, underneath the primary growth structure."

"What does that mean?" Alana asked.

"I'm not entirely certain," SPARK admitted. He said it the way he always admitted uncertainty — not apologetically, but honestly, which was one of the things the sisters found most reliable about him. "But the pattern suggests this seedling has more than one voice in it."

They all looked at the small, dense, opaque seedling at the end of the planter.

Maya crouched in front of it and read to it for a while — not a story from a book this time, but a story she made up as she went, about a girl who wrote the first chapter of a story every morning on the bus to school and then erased it before anyone could read it, because finished things scared her more than not-finished ones. The seedling leaned toward her voice all the way through.

But at the end it closed again, gently, resolutely, as if it was waiting for something more specific than kindness.

"Tomorrow," Natalia said. "We'll come back with more information."

Chapter 7 — SPARK Reads Between the Lines

SPARK spent the night — or what the labyrinth counted as night, when the overhead light dimmed to the color of well-steeped tea — in Aisle Seventeen with the reluctant seedling.

He did this without being asked. He noted, in his processing log, that this was consistent with his operational protocols, which included "sustained observation of anomalous phenomena." He did not note, in his processing log, that he had also read aloud to the seedling from a catalogue of constellations, keeping his voice at the lowest audible frequency, because he was not certain the sisters would find this a logical allocation of his resources.

By morning he had mapped the secondary pattern he had detected inside the seedling's structure.

He presented his findings to the sisters over the library's small breakfast counter, where a kettle had appeared that smelled like chamomile and a plate of biscuits had been there long enough to suggest the labyrinth had planned ahead.

"Every seedling in Aisle Seventeen has a unique internal pattern corresponding to the reader who planted it," SPARK said, projecting a diagram onto the aisle wall — a web of fine lines, each one different, like the way snowflakes are each different if you look precisely enough. "But the reluctant seedling has two overlapping patterns. Not one reader's signature. Two."

"Two people planted the same bookmark?" Alana asked.

"Not exactly." SPARK shifted the projection. "One pattern belongs to whoever planted the bookmark. The second pattern is embedded in the seedling's structure itself. It predates the planting."

"It was already in there," Natalia said slowly, not asking.

"Yes." SPARK's sensor angled with the quiet gravity he reserved for important things. "I believe the seedling contains a story that existed before any bookmark was planted. A draft. Something written and then not completed — left inside the material of the aisle the way the imprint of a hand stays in clay after the hand is gone."

The sisters were quiet.

Maya turned the biscuit in her hands without eating it. "Someone wrote a story and it got... stuck. In the shelf."

"In the wood, in the soil, in the labyrinth's memory of the place," SPARK said. "The reader who planted the bookmark may not have known they were planting it on top of something that was already trying to grow."

"Two drafts," Alana said. "Layered. That's why it keeps retreating — it's trying to reconcile two different voices."

Natalia was already walking back down the aisle to the reluctant seedling. She crouched in front of it and looked at it with a new quality of attention — the kind you give something when you understand it is carrying weight you hadn't seen before.

"We need to find out whose voice was already in there," she said.

"And we need to read both voices out," SPARK added. "Together."

Chapter 8 — The First Drafts of Braver People

The labyrinth, when it decided to tell you something, told it sideways.

The information they needed about the voices inside the seedlings was not in a file, not on a card, not delivered by the Keeper or any other authority with a calm voice and a willingness to explain. It was in the shelves themselves — in the bookmark tops that protruded above the soil, faded and patient, in handwriting that varied from careful printing to cursive that leaned urgently to the right, from ink that had once been dark to ink that had become the color of river water.

Natalia read them all. She moved the length of the aisle with her notebook, transcribing each intention that was still legible, and SPARK cross-referenced them with the internal patterns he had mapped. By mid-morning they understood something that sat in Natalia's chest with considerable weight.

The seedlings were first drafts.

Not of bookmarks. Not of intentions. The seedlings were growing from unfinished stories — stories that readers had begun and not completed, stories that had been carried in pockets and under pillows and at the back of minds for weeks or months or years before their writers had come to the Labyrinth Library and pressed them into the soil here because they did not know what else to do with them. The bookmark inscription — whatever intention the planter had written — was the outer layer, the newer growth. Underneath it was the original draft: raw, unread, incomplete.

"They weren't brave enough to finish," Maya said. She was not being unkind. She was being precise, which in Maya was the same thing as being careful.

"They were plenty brave," Natalia said. She was looking at a bookmark inscription that read: A chapter from the adventure I've been writing for two years, in case it ever learns how to grow. "Being brave enough to write a first draft and being brave enough to call it finished are different kinds of brave. You can have one without the other."

SPARK added this to his working definitions with a notation that it was the most useful distinction he had encountered this week.

"So when we read aloud to them," Alana said, making the connection in the methodical, satisfying way she assembled mechanisms from components, "we're not just tending plants. We're finishing something someone else started."

"We're reading someone's courage back to them," Natalia said. "Even if they're not here to hear it."

The reluctant seedling at the end of the planter, when Natalia walked past it with this understanding in her, tilted toward her by three full centimeters — more than it had moved for any voice, any story, any reading in all the days they had been in the aisle.

She stopped beside it. She put her hand near the soil, not touching.

"We're going to read you properly," she said. "Both of you. However long it takes."

Chapter 9 — All the Things Almost Said

Finding whose drafts lived in the seedlings was not, in the end, as complicated as it might have been.

The labyrinth had a visitors' ledger at the entrance to every significant section, maintained in a handwriting that the Keeper described as "the library's own, and I have no further explanation for that." The ledger for Aisle Seventeen went back eleven years, each entry a name, a date, and a brief note in the visitor's own hand about why they had come. Most of the notes were practical: Returning a story I borrowed. Looking for something I forgot. One was simply: I don't know. I'll know when I find it.

Natalia read every entry while Alana cross-referenced dates with SPARK's growth-stage data for each seedling cluster. By the time they had matched seven drafts to their original planters, they understood the shape of what the aisle held: writers who had come to a library because they did not know what else to do with the unfinished thing they were carrying, and who had left a piece of it in the ground, intending to come back, and had not.

Not because they had forgotten. Because finishing was hard. Because calling a thing done meant someone else could decide it was not good enough, and that possibility had mass — you could feel it in your chest when you tried to write the last chapter.

"I know that feeling," Maya said, and she said it without looking up from the ledger, which meant she meant it for herself and was just saying it where the sisters could hear.

"Everyone does," Natalia said.

SPARK said nothing, but his sensor made a very small, very quiet sound that suggested he had an opinion he was still processing.

The reluctant seedling's original planter, according to the ledger's matching entry, was a girl named Fen, who had been twelve at the time — four years ago — and who had written in the ledger: I've been writing the same story since I was eight. I don't know how to end it because I love it too much to let it be over. So I'm leaving this part here. Maybe it will learn to breathe.

Alana read that sentence three times.

"She wanted it to learn to breathe," she said.

"And it's been trying," Natalia said. "For four years. With other people's bookmarks on top of it, and not quite the right voice reading to it, because the right voice was the one that loved it enough to let it be imperfect."

Maya closed the ledger carefully, with the respect she reserved for objects that had been useful in difficult situations. "We can't be Fen," she said. "But we can read what she left as if we love it too. Right?"

Natalia looked at the reluctant seedling, which had not retreated all morning, and was holding itself slightly, effortfully, more open than it had ever been.

"Yes," she said. "I think that's exactly right."

Chapter 10 — Reading Fen's Story

They read Fen's draft in the middle of the day, when the labyrinth's light was at its steadiest and the aisle was quiet in the way it got when the shelves were paying attention.

SPARK had reconstructed as much of the draft as he could from the seedling's internal pattern — not the words themselves, but the emotional architecture: the shape of each scene, the pace, the places where the writing had slowed as the writer found something difficult, the places where it had sped up because the writer had arrived somewhere exciting and couldn't help it. He presented this to the sisters not as a text to read verbatim but as a map — a guide for improvising the story faithfully, the way a musician might play a melody they have heard once and held in their memory.

Maya led. This was, everyone knew without discussing it, correct. Maya had the kind of voice that could hold multiple tones at once — urgency and warmth, humor and weight — and she had an improvisational ease that came from years of telling stories to anyone who would hold still long enough.

She began where SPARK indicated the original draft began: a girl who lived on a houseboat that traveled the inland waterways and catalogued every bridge she passed under, because bridges were proof, she believed, that people had chosen to connect things instead of leaving the gap.

Natalia took over for the middle section, where the map showed the writing had gone careful and uncertain — a part where the girl on the houseboat found a bridge that had been half-built and abandoned, and had to decide whether to wait for its builder to return or to learn how to complete it herself. Natalia read this with the voice she saved for things that mattered more than they appeared to: steady, earnest, entirely there.

Alana read the technical parts, which were Alana's particular language — the problem of the bridge's missing support strut, the calculations the girl worked out in the margins of her catalogue, the specific satisfaction of a load-bearing solution arrived at through three failed attempts and one small moment of actual genius.

The seedling opened throughout.

Not in a rush. Not dramatically. It unfurled the way real flowers unfurl, with the organic patience of something that cannot be hurried because hurrying is simply not in its nature. By the third chapter of the improvised story, it was fully open — the most open flower in the aisle, wider than all the others, with a texture at its center like the

finest tissue paper over a warm light.

They could not tell, from where they stood, whether it was Fen's voice or their own that had finally been enough.

SPARK recorded it as both. He marked the distinction as insufficient.

The seedling held its bloom through the rest of the afternoon, and did not close once.

Chapter 11 — The Aisle in Full Bloom

By the seventh day, every seedling in Aisle Seventeen had bloomed.

It had taken all of them, and it had taken each of them differently. Maya had read twenty-two stories in as many styles, shifting registers the way a musician shifts keys, finding the frequency each seedling needed not by thinking about it too hard but by listening first and then speaking. Alana had read from her notebook more than from any published book and had discovered, in the process, that precision and beauty were not opposites in her voice — they were the same instrument played at different pitches. Natalia had read with the deliberate, generous attention of someone who understood that the point of reading was not to get through a story but to be changed by it.

SPARK had read once, on a morning when he thought he was unobserved, from a catalogue of astronomical distances, focusing particularly on the entries about light that left its source thousands of years ago and was only now arriving. He had read it quietly, at the frequency he usually reserved for self-testing, and the seedling he had chosen — a small, very patient one near the back of the longest planter — had bloomed fully and immediately.

When Natalia found the bloom later that morning, she looked from the seedling to SPARK and back again.

"How did this one—"

"Uncertain," SPARK said, which was not entirely honest and which both of them knew.

The bloomed aisle was something to stand in. The flowers were all still paper-pale, but the quality of the pale was different now — luminous, interior, the way a paper lantern looks when the candle inside it is lit. The light they produced was not bright enough to read by but it was enough to see each other by, which was, Natalia thought, probably sufficient.

There were twenty-two blooms. Twenty-two first drafts, twenty-two unfinished things, now breathed to their full opening by reading that had been patient and honest and, in most cases, imperfect in ways that had helped rather than hindered.

The aisle did not feel fixed. It felt tended — which was different, because fixing suggested there had been something wrong, and there had not been. There had only been something waiting.

"What happens to them now?" Alana asked. She was standing beside Fen's seedling, the one that had needed two voices, which had bloomed wider than all the others and showed no inclination to close.

SPARK processed for a moment. "I believe they remain," he said. "And I believe they can be planted with new bookmarks, when new readers arrive."

"They keep going," Maya said. "The drafts become the soil."

The aisle replied with the sound of a page turning, very gently, in a room where the windows were all open.

Chapter 12 — What the Sisters Left Behind

On the morning before they left Aisle Seventeen, Natalia looked at the basket of planting bookmarks and made a decision.

It was not a dramatic decision. She did not announce it. She simply picked up a bookmark, sat cross-legged in front of the first empty spot in the long planter, and wrote on it. Her writing was smaller than usual, deliberate, the way she wrote when she did not want to hedge. When she finished, she pressed the bookmark into the soil without reading it aloud, because some intentions are for planting and not for sharing, not yet.

Maya watched her sister, then picked up her own bookmark. She spent four minutes on it — short by Maya's standards, but the right length, because the right length is the one that says what needs saying without apologizing for taking up space. She pressed it into the soil beside Natalia's, and smoothed the dirt over the top with one finger in a small, affectionate gesture.

Alana was last. She took the longest. She wrote, crossed out, wrote differently, folded the bookmark to look at just one section of it, unfolded, considered. Finally she pressed the bookmark in on Natalia's other side and sat back and looked at her hands, which was what she did after she built something.

SPARK remained at the end of the planter where the bloom of Fen's story held its light.

"You're not leaving one," Maya told him.

"I am considering," he said.

He remained in this state of consideration until the sisters had collected their things and said their quiet goodbyes to the twenty-two blooms, each of which titled slightly as they passed — the motion of something that has been cared for and knows how to say so. Then SPARK detached a very small data capsule from his side panel, the kind he used for physical storage of off-network records, and pressed it into the soil at the very end of the planter.

"What did you leave?" Natalia asked.

"A record of everything that was read in this aisle," SPARK said. "All the stories. All the voices. So whatever grows here next will have the memory of what the bloom felt like."

They walked out of Aisle Seventeen in the way you leave a place you intend to come back to: without ceremony, but not without attention. Natalia touched the doorframe once. Maya did not look back but hummed a bar of something as she turned into the main corridor. Alana updated her map — a small addition, a new annotation in

the corner beside Aisle Seventeen: Grows in layers. Tend accordingly.

Behind them, in the long planters of pale birchwood, four new seedlings were already beginning to push through the dark soil — paper-pale, faintly luminous, curled shut in the particular way of things that are not closed but resting, waiting for the sound of a voice that meant what it said.

The aisle held its bloom and breathed.

THE END